

MYLAPORE

Mandaveli » R A Puram » Royapettah » Chindatripet » Royapuram » Korukkupet » Ennore » Luz » Alwarpet » Triplicane » Central

Washermenpet » Tondiarpet » Manali » M.R.C.Nagar » Teynampet » Mount Road » Broadway » Kondithope » Tiruvotiyur



ALONE WITH THE TIMEPIECES

At Peer & Sons on Kutcheri Road, a son is keeping his father's memory alive by enthusiastically practising a skill imparted to him by the senior **P4**



'COOKING UP' A CHALLENGE FOR WOMEN CHEFS

Over 70 participants took part in this competition designed to test their culinary knowledge and kitchen skills **P6**

The target: fifty programmes in the fiftieth year

On August 14, Triplicane-based social welfare organisation SYMA set foot in its fiftieth year which it seeks to make memorable through a series of social initiatives

Srinivas Young Men's Association (SYMA) entered its 50th year on August 14 and marked the milestone doing just that which has brought it so far: social service.

The Triplicane-based welfare organisation has launched a host of initiatives to make its Golden Jubilee year memorable.

Four programmes were conducted to commemorate the 50th year, and the plan is to take up a total of 50 events through the year, says a press release.

His holiness Sri Sri Raghuvarendra Theertha Swamiji of Srimad Achyuthaprekshacharya Maha-



During the inauguration of the eye camp.

samsthana, Sri Bheemanakatte Matha, Udipi inaugurated the celebrations on August 14 by unveiling a framed photo of the 50th year.

Swamiji appreciated SYMA for

its activities in healthcare and education. 'Planting of Trees' was rolled out with Swamiji planting a tree at SYMA Medical Centre. The association has planted 10 trees in

the streets of Triplicane and has plans to plant around 50 trees in the coming days.

On August 15, the National Flag was hoisted to mark Independence

day at the Medical Centre by chief guest S. R. Balachandar, chief compliance officer, secretarial, Royal Sundaram General Insurance Company Limited. He also inaugurated the eye camp. Members of Soundarya Rathnamala Isai Kuzhu sang patriotic songs to mark the occasion.

The free cataract camp was conducted in association with Sri Sankara Eye Hospital, Pammal and Sri Kanchi Kamakoti Sankara Medical Trust. Around 139 patients were screened out of which 20 persons who had cataract were selected for free operation. Apart from this, 40 persons were identified for whom the Association has arranged to provide spectacles free of cost. The distribution of spectacles will be done on August 25 in memory of Late K. E. Raghavan who has done great service at SYMA Medical Centre, said a release.

On August 16, Sri Sudarshana Homam was conducted at the medical centre for world peace. Priests from Singaperumal Koil conducted the homam. Prasadam were distributed to many members of the public.

Spencer Plaza junction then and now



The members of JACTTEA and Teachers Organisations blocking traffic on Anna Salai on July 22, 1988; and a photo of the road taken on August 22, 2026.

PHOTO: THE HINDU ARCHIVES and B. Jothi Ramalingam

Two-day property expo in September



The Hindu Property Expo - 2026 will be held on September 5 and 6 at Chennai Trade Centre, Nandambakkam.

Visitors can explore a wide range of premium residences, plots, farmlands, farmhouses, commercial spaces, and investment opportunities. The expo offers an opportunity to meet developers, compare projects, understand available options, and make informed property decisions. Scan the QR code to register or visit: newsth.live/PFC2026PA

For details, call 9841273713 / 9841810070



Why are abandoned cars dumped behind Lighthouse?

R. KASIM RAZVI

A number of cars, either having slowly gone to seed or having been involved in accidents, are parked behind the Lighthouse along the Marina Loop Road. The stretch is gradually beginning to resemble a dumping yard, raising concerns about public safety, cleanliness and the appearance of one of the city's prominent waterfront areas. It is unclear why these vehicles are being kept here and under whose authority. The authorities concerned should clarify the reason for parking these vehicles at the site and take steps to remove them at the earliest.

R. Kasim Razvi is a resident of Mylapore



You can be our volunteer writer

Dear readers, you can be our volunteer-writer by writing to us about issues and events in your neighbourhood. You should send the write-ups to downtownfeedback@thehindu.co.in. Letters must carry the contact number.



As Metro Rail work progresses, Luz traffic takes a further hit

ARUSH DEY

At Luz Church Road in Mylapore, near Navasakthi Vinayagar Koil, traffic has gotten worse. With Metro Rail construction activity happening almost everywhere in the Luz area, the place was already difficult to navigate. It has now become more difficult to do so.

The Luz Church Road has become extremely narrow, making it hugely difficult for motorists to pass through, which is why traffic jam is increasing by the day. With a developer undertaking construction at one side, even autos find it difficult to come to the area. Whenever an auto is booked, the ride gets cancelled.



Just a couple of days ago, many cars and taxis were parked near Navasakthi Vinayagar Koil that added to the chaos. Students from Vidya Mandir and nearby schools

who come by walk also find it difficult. Something must be done to regulate traffic on this stretch.

Arush Dey is a resident of Mylapore



Parked vehicles block streets in Abhiramapuram

RAJAGOPAL J.K.

Abhiramapuram 1st Street at the intersection of Abhiramapuram 4th Main Road is narrow and has one side of the road declared as a no parking zone.

However the nearby restaurants,

schools and coffee shops offer valet parking through the day resulting in repeated incidents of parked vehicles blocking the narrow stretch and inconveniencing the free flow of traffic. A request to the drivers to avoid parking is usually met with an arrogant response.

Similar issues of indiscriminate parking are faced along the narrow stretch of Subramaniam Street.

Rajagopal is a resident of RA Puram

'Issue pass with double-sided carbon paper'

P. SATHYANARAYANAN

Recently, Southern Railway stated that it would provide laminated covers along with paper season passes to prevent details on the ticket from fading. This is because many commuters complained that their season passes became undecipherable within days.

Recently, a college student was fined ₹510 after the details on her monthly season pass faded within a week, only the serial number was denoted. Southern Railway should print the passes with double-sided carbon sheets.

The first copy of the pass should be submitted to commuters, and the second re-

tained by the railways.

The commuters should note the serial number and the date on which the pass was issued. If the details in the passes get faded, it can be obtained through the serial number and on the date when the pass was obtained.

P. Sathyanarayanan is a resident of Guindy



A walkthrough in R.A. Puram

Acceding to the request from Raja Annamalaipuram Residents Association (RAPRA), the Regional Deputy Commissioner of Greater Chennai Corporation, H.R. Kaushik visited R.A. Puram with his team of officials and Urbaser officials for inspection of some roads that needed GCC's attention.

The RDC went through the petition and discussed the issues mentioned therein with his team and gave them on-the-spot directions to redress the issues. It was not a routine meeting. Immediately after exchange of introductions RDC, his team of officials such as the Zonal Officer, Executive Engineer, other divisional officials along with urbaser team of officials who accompanied him, commenced the walk to inspect some of the issues that were plaguing the residents, says the press release.

During the walkthrough, the RDC and residents had an interaction that was informal and friendly. All credits should go to the RDC for making the atmosphere light so that the residents expressed their views without any inhibition. The RDC spotted ac-



H.R. Kaushik, regional deputy commissioner, GCC, interacts with residents

cumulated trash behind a street name board and pointed that to his staff for clearance. He also noticed unauthorised hoardings on lamp posts and guided his officials not only to remove them but also to penalise the offenders.

As regards the stray dog menace arising from an abandoned building he directed his team to have them dealt by GCC dog squad appropriately. He agreed that a bus shelter on Second Main Road close to the Traffic Signal is

a cause for traffic snarls and asked his team to take appropriate action. Overhead Internet and TV cables would be properly bunched and the illegal ones removed, he assured. All cattle from that area would be moved to

the Goshala, which is under construction. It would take a couple of months he said.

The stormwater drain on the flood prone Third Main Road would be cleaned well ahead of the monsoon and connected properly to the Canal, he assured. He said that Owners of abandoned vehicles would be served notice and if not removed within the stipulated time, the vehicles would be removed, the release adds.

He stressed the need for source segregation of garbage and wanted RAPRA to be a model for this cause. The Information, Communication and Education (ICE) team of Urbaser that were also part of the walk would create awareness among the residents in the coming days he said.

On the whole none felt the tedium of the long walk covering five long roads on a sunny afternoon because of the lively engagement and interaction with the RDC. The residents never felt that a senior IAS officer would be all ears to the residents and never once showed that he was a big official. Residents felt that this walk of RDC would be a game changer to their roads.

Kids hog the limelight at I-Day celebrations

Raja Annamalaipuram Residents Association (RAPRA) made its Independence Day celebration truly special, especially for children in the community. About three months ago, RAPRA Kids Club was started exclusively for children to teach them team spirit, civic sense and moral values. The children are groomed by six lady members of RAPRA who passionately spend time with them every fortnight.

This Independence Day, these children dressed as freedom fighters like Mahatma Gandhi, Subash Chandra Bose, Rani Velu Nachiyar, Veerapandiya Kattabomman, Kittu Chinnamma, Rani Lakshmi Bai, Bal Gangadhar Tilak, Bharati, Kappalottiya Thamizhan, Annie Besant, Bhagat Singh and Tiruppur Kumaran spoke few lines about the characters they were donning. A few patriotic songs in Villu paatu style was also sung by them. The flawless performance by these children was due to the training by both the mentors and the parents, said a release. The children were given gift hampers by the president Dr. R. Chandrasekaran.

The president spoke about freedom struggle and said teachers and parents play a vital role in



shaping the children, who are the future. P. Rajagopal, partner, Sangheetha Restaurant was the chief guest. He hoisted the tri colour and exhorted the residents to cherish the freedom obtained after big sacrifice by freedom fighters.

Musical evening

At Ragamalika Apartment in Mandaveli, children performed songs,

group dance, skit and gave talk. The evening celebration had a good number of children who took part.

Madhu Iyer, Ramya and Shyam, all professional singers of the apartment, sang both patriotic and old film songs for nearly two hours.

Harini Ramesh took the initiative to make this celebration successful, said a release.

Annual Independence Day chess contest conducted

Kalaa Manjari Creativity Center in Alwarpet is all set to start morning chess classes for adults

Kalaa Manjari Creativity Center in Alwarpet successfully concluded the 16th edition of its Independence Day Chess Competition. Young chess enthusiasts in four categories took part: Sub Junior, Junior, Senior, and Super Senior.

The annual Independence Day Chess Competition has become an eagerly anticipated event for young chess players, providing them with an opportunity to compete, challenge themselves, and develop important life skills such as logical thinking, patience, concentration, and decision-making, said a release.

Kalaa Manjari Creativity Center is a skill-development centre for children and adults, with a vision to promote "skills beyond academics" and support holistic



development. The centre offers programmes including art (in association with Global Art), Chess, Karate, English Handwriting, Phonetics and Tuitions.

Kalaa Manjari will soon be launching special morning classes for adults, designed to provide a relaxed and creative space to de-stress, learn something new, and rediscover hobbies.

For enquiries and registrations, call 98402 25570 | 91766 10660

Ticking on behind the barricades

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

Zenith Watch Co at
Kutchery Road in
Mylapore.

Somewhere between the ticking of a century-old pendulum clock and a modern, sleek wrist watch, Zenith Watch Co. on Kutchery Road has ensured two distinct eras of time live side by side. A sweep of the eye taking in the walls of this shop that stares at Metro Rail barricades presents this sumptuous display of the past and the present. The walls are decorated with old, ornate timepieces, repaired and ready for delivery; and these walls also display shelves holding modern wristwatches out of factories and packed ready for sale.

Since 1954, this shop at Kutchery Road, near Luz signal in Mylapore, has been serving customers seeking to preserve timepieces of the past, hallowed by their personal memories, as well as watches and clocks just out of the blocks and dew-fresh in the market.

Founded by Mallick Pasha, the shop has never had a change of address. And even in these difficult times, when Metro Rail work has redrawn pathways, both for pedestrians and motorists, the shop resiliently stays put at this address. Mahaboob Pasha, who runs this family business, points out that even old customers accustomed to walking through the doors of this shop struggle to find their way to those familiar doors, as Metro Rail work has engineered a maze of new pathways through route diversions and blockages. By virtue of the diversity of its services, Zenith depends on revisits by old customers as well as walk-ins by new ones. The “barricades” across Luz Corner, on Kutchery Road and Luz Church Road hinder both processes.

“New customers find it difficult to notice the shop, while the old ones find it difficult to reach the shop,” he says.

But Mahaboob sounds like someone who has taken these challenges in his stride. At 58, this man has spent more than three decades amidst the “chimes of time”, having taken over the reins of the shop when he was in his twenties. Back then for this M.Com graduate, there was no dearth of career options. “This is a family business and I cannot leave it; hence I chose this,” he says. There was a time when he worked alongside the technicians at the shop, as a repairer of timepieces. Today, he sticks to

the management side of the business, leaving the repair of broken and malfunctioning timepieces to the technicians on the rolls. Mahaboob notes spare parts are sourced from Mumbai and Delhi when they are unavailable locally.

On whether a plethora of other devices marking time such as the mobile phone, the laptop and so on have made a dent in the attraction of the wristwatch, his answer is an emphatic ‘no’. Mahaboob observes that it remains firmly where it belongs: on the wrist. Largely for inveterate followers and buyers of new wristwatch models, Zenith stocks up on non-branded wristwatches, largely wallet-friendly.

On retaining his old customer base, Mahaboob notes hospitality on the other side of the counter remains an effective glue keeping that loyalty intact. While valuing face-to-face, in-person interactions, Zenith has ensured the connections are sustained by technology. Its website allows customers to track repairs using their bill numbers; it showcases wristwatches, wall clocks, and other timepieces for sale. So, what is it that sustains Zenith as it is hemmed in by Metro Rail barricades? This probably: keeping stride with technology without losing that personal, human touch.

Established in 1954, seller and mender of timepieces Zenith Watch Co at Kutchery Road in Mylapore has never had a change of address. In recent times, it has been facing a massive challenge on account of route diversions and road blockages caused by Metro Rail work. The enterprise however seems to have taken this difficulty in its stride. A little distance away, on the same road is a one-man enterprise Peer & Sons, established in 1963, that repairs watches and clocks; and it displays similar fortitude



Celebrating Madras Day (August 22), Resilience Series tracks old markets and enterprises in the city that are under the shadow of a major civic infrastructure work but are soldiering on with inimitable poise.



“New customers find it difficult to notice the shop, while the old ones find it difficult to reach the shop.”

Alone with the timepieces

At Peer & Sons on Kutchery Road, a son is keeping his father’s memory alive by enthusiastically practising a skill imparted to him by the senior

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

On that part of Kutchery Road, where the Buckingham Canal flows sluggishly under a bridge, S. Shakil Ahmed operates from a shop smaller than a niche in a dovecote. The shop was once larger, recalls Shakil, but as the owner reclaimed a part of it for another enterprise, it shrunk to its present dimensions. But this small shop still catches the eye for its wall displays: clocks, either *demode* or delectably antique, depending on the eye beholding them. Another eye-catching feature is the enseigne above the entrance that announces the enterprise as Peer & Sons. When quizzed about the name and its homonymic alignment with the iconic P. Orr & Sons on Mount Road, Shakil sounds a tad amused as he offers a reply: obviously, when they see this shop, they know the two are galaxies apart. But when they hear the name ‘Peer & Sons’ over the phone, they would be confused for a split second. And the name was not carefully chosen to evoke that iconic shop, remarks Shakil, just to reflect that it was started by his father S.K. Peer.

S.K. Peer had opened this shop in 1963 and continued in the saddle till his demise in 2008. Shakil relishes reminiscing about the unquestioning obedience with which he followed in his father’s footsteps, not in 2008 but way back in 1991 when the senior was at the height of his prowess as a mender of timepieces and he was just a school student. Shakil joined his father as his understudy in 1991, right after finishing his Class X board exams.

“I did not even wait for my results,” he says with a faint laugh at the memory.

“If my father asked for something, it was always a yes,” states Shakil, his decision driven by a straightforward logic: if his father needed him at the shop, that was reason enough to be there.

He observes that for parents to get a ‘yes’ from their children today, they would have to first answer a gazillion ‘whys’. Shakil, who has three children, two girls and a boy, all of them falling within the Gen Z bracket, is at peace with the current generation’s questioning mindset as they are spoilt for choice in terms of career options, and have information at hand to suss those careers out.

To a question if he ever regrets not having taken a different career path, Shakil’s answer is a ‘no’, but he qualifies it by admitting that on rare occasions,



S. Shakil Ahmed at Peer & Sons on Kutchery Road.

the thought has crossed his mind. That thought most likely occurred during the pandemic and in recent times, on account of Metro Rail work at the Luz Corner (where Kutchery Road meets Luz Church Road meet) restricting access to his shop. That thought gets counterbalanced by his awareness of the benefits of being one’s own boss.

“If there is a function, I can attend it without prior leave complications; if I want to travel, I can take a few days off and do so,” he smiles.

He has commendably built a livelihood just by the practice of the craft of repairing timepieces, has managed to give his children good and meaningful education (the two daughters are in college and the son in school).

After his father’s death in 2008, Shakil has been running the shop in a veritable one-man show spending that vast chunk of his waking hours (that is, from 10.a.m. to 9p.m.), sitting hunched over timepieces, peering at them through a magnifying eyepiece. The punch-in punch-out time is sometimes longer: during the pandemic, he began taking delicate and major repairs home, a habit that has stuck with him ever since. His workbench has witnessed everything from a Seiko to a 1960s Omega; and also those ornate tall, weight-driven pendulum clocks, colloquially called grandfather and grandmother clocks depending on their height and size. His customer base includes collectors of antique clocks. He accepts every timepiece that comes his way, from the grand to the commonplace. Repairs of antique clocks can soak up considerable time.

Availability of spare parts can sometimes pose a challenge. When unable to find spare parts, he has fashioned them himself, says Shakil. But obviously, there is a limit to what you can fashion yourself; the sustainable option is to have dealers who can hand them over to you. On a normal day though, he sources spares from dealers. He also buys old clocks to salvage those parts that are in working order.

Now, the question that stares at any enterprise sustained by successive generations. Would the next generation take the baton from Shakil and continue the legacy started by his father S.K. Peer? His children might likely choose different fields, and Shakil admits the possibility of the business continuing through them being thin. For now, Shakil remains at his bench, turning back time by getting old timepieces ticking again. And he luxuriates in the sweet sound of a timepiece ticking and sounding back to life.

Free and subsidised dialysis service providers in Chennai



LIFFY THOMAS

16 and counting

It was after a stint in Canada that nephrologist Georgi Abraham decided to start a dialysis centre at Chennai in the mid-2000s.

The Tanker Foundation Dialysis Centre started in a humble way at Georgi Abraham’s father-in-law’s house on Poonamalee High Road as it was lying vacant.

As the number of patients seeking dialysis began to shoot up, the Foundation sought a space at Rotary Ambattur Hospital where it got started on the initiative with five machines. Today, the upgraded hospital has 26 machines with 127 patients seeking dialysis under its care.

In the last two decades, this initiative to provide dialysis for patients twice or thrice a week has grown to serve people from various parts of Chennai and beyond. Dialysis is offered either free or at a subsidised rate of ₹ 375 to patients, says a note on its website.

Of the 16 centres run in Tamil Nadu by Tanker Foundation, 11 are in Chennai. “A majority of the patients are enrolled under the Chief Minister Scheme and if expenses beyond that need to be covered we find donors,” says Dr. Georgi Abraham, founder-president of the Tanker Foundation.

The patients have the choice of

opting for a centre that is closest to their home. “A patient whose kidney function is between 6 and 8 percent is eligible for dialysis, but we are particular that certain criteria are met including the financial background of the person and dialysis in an OP setting for free treatment,” says Dr. Georgi.

With rising number of kidney-related ailments, the Foundation sees a huge demand for this from of service. People who require early detection are those with high BP, history of diabetes, complaints of heart disease and a previous history of kidney disease.

For details about its various centres, visit <https://tankerfoundation.org>

***GCC-run centres

Greater Chennai Corporation runs dialysis centres in a majority of its zones. As per data put up on X, Zone IX has the maximum number of dialysis machines, 22. The unit functions from Vallorkottam Diagnostic Centre in Nungambakkam. Others are in Thiruvottiyur UCHC, Lakshmiapuram in Rerteri UPHC, Elango Nagar UPHC, Padi Ambattur UCHC, Chinnai Porur in Valsarvakam UCHC; Perungudi, Injambakkam and Semmacherry UCHC;

These centres are operated with the support of NGOs and organisations. Dialysis treatment is offered free-of-cost at these centres.

Care at ₹ 600

Since Chennai Lions Dialysis Foundation started in Thiruvanniyur in 2011, one thing that has stayed constant is its affordable pricing. In all these 15 years, the Foundation charges ₹ 600 per sitting from those seeking dialysis.

Started as a pet project of Lion R. Ravichandran, Past District Governor, the Foundation offers dialysis treatment for close to 250 people a month at its six-bed dialysis centre.

The cost of a single haemodialysis session ranges from ₹1800 to ₹ 3,500 in city hospitals. “Since patients need to undergo dialysis sessions two to three times a week, the monthly cost of treatment can run into several thousand rupees. We started this service to alleviate some of the hardships faced by dialysis patients and their families,” says Ravichandran.

The remaining costs are covered by the Foundation. “Although we do face shortage of funds we have somehow been able to sustain this service with the support of donors,” he says.

Nephrologist R. Vijay Kumar is the consultant guiding the Foundation.

Chennai Lions Dialysis Foundation is at No 28A, South Mada Street, Thiruvanniyur, near Marundeeswarar Temple.

For details, call Ravichandran at 98410 51480/ Kalyani Ngarajan at 9841115984.

‘Cooking up’ a challenge for women chefs

Over 70 participants took part in this competition designed to test their culinary knowledge and kitchen skills

BY A SPECIAL CORRESPONDENT

This dish came to India from Indonesia, according to famous food historian KT Achaya. Cooks employed by Indonesian Hindu kings are believed to have made it between the 9th and 12th centuries. Name the dish.

* Designed by chemist Fred Baur using advanced computing to solve issues with broken and greasy-bagged snacks, this product's signature saddle-like shape is a mathematically optimised hyperbolic paraboloid. It comes packed in canisters to withstand transport pressure. Which engineered snack brand is this?

These two are among the questions that were posted to participants at QuizDiva, a culinary competition for women chefs, culinary professionals, and hospital-



The winners along with dignitaries at the event.

ity students from South India, held at Institute of Hotel Management in Taramani recently.

Over 70 participants found their knowledge and culinary skills tested through different rounds. There were three top prizes worth ₹ 1 lakh, ₹75,000 and ₹ 50,000 to be taken away.

Designed to celebrate talent, creativity, and professional excellence, the event organised by X Quiz IT with South India Chefs Association (SICA) as collaborators

tested the participants on practical culinary challenges, knowledge of food and kitchen skills.

The quiz segments were conducted by X Quiz IT's founder and creative head Arvind Rajeev, while the overall event was handled by Arun Jayakaran Ventures (AJV). “We have done quiz competitions for chefs in the past but this is the first time we were doing something exclusively for lady chefs who were in the fray to showcase their expertise in theo-

ry and practicals. We wanted them to look beyond the books,” says quizzier Arvind Rajeev.

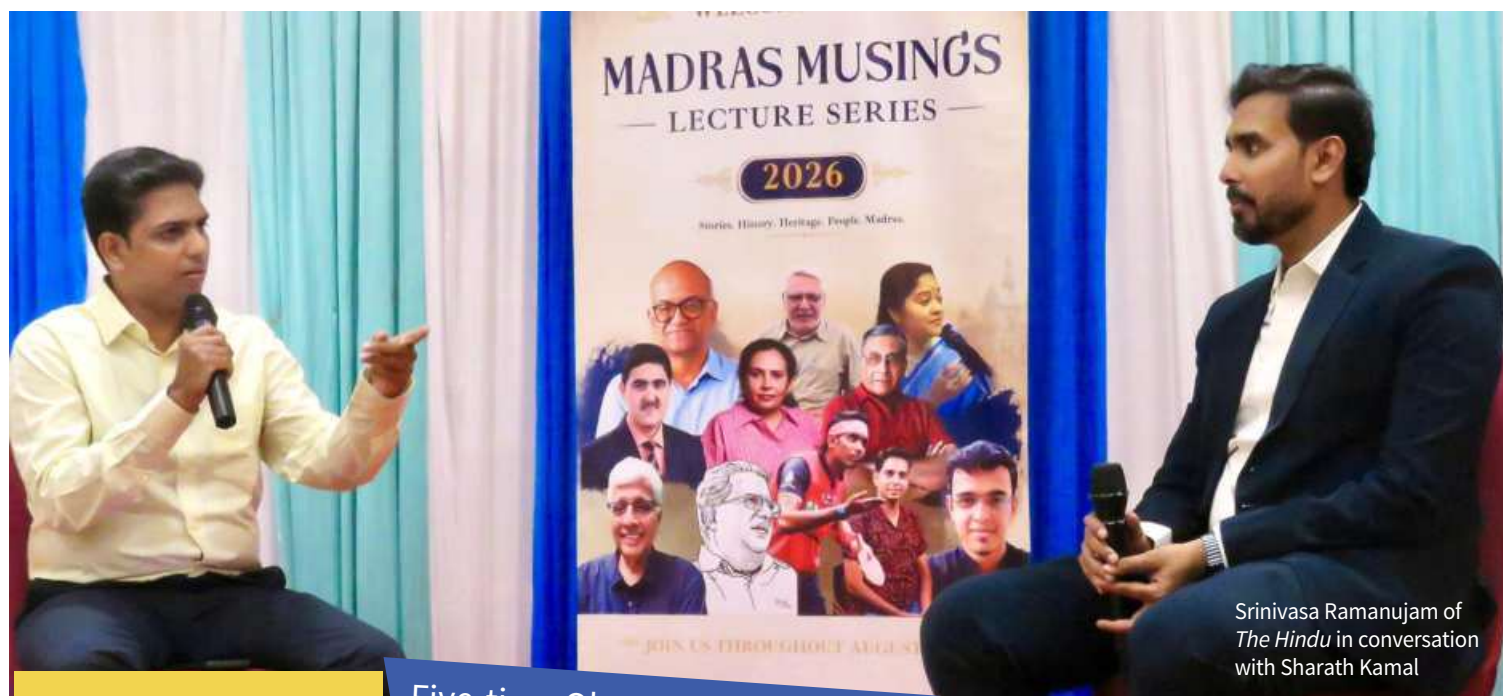
With women in the hospitality industry playing an important role, QuizDiva served as a platform for recognising and encouraging them.

Niranjana Murugesan Durai, a resident of Chennai, won the first prize. After a stint in the hotel industry, she is currently running her own home-based cloud kitchen and plans to use the cash

prize in her business.

Rubah Fathima and Nandhita Sriram were declared second and third prize winners respectively. A new experience for these chefs, the winners pointed out that having a quiz format in the challenge made them take “strategic guesses” and also admire the many female chefs in the industry.

Actor Thalaivasal Vijay was the special guest and he gave away the prizes.



Srinivasa Ramanujam of *The Hindu* in conversation with Sharath Kamal

From tracks to table

Five-time Olympian and table tennis legend Sharath Kamal shares his Madras memories

When table tennis champion Sharath Kamal watched *MS Dhoni: The Untold Story* (2016), he was almost in tears. Much like Dhoni, the now-popular paddler was once a railway TTE at the

Mambalam station in Madras. “There is a scene in the film that has Sushant Singh Rajput (who played Dhoni) sitting in a bench, watching trains go by and wondering if he would remain a ticket collector all his life. I have sat in sta-

tions in Madras exactly like that, before I saw success in table tennis,” recalled Sharath.

One of India's most celebrated table tennis players, Sharath went down memory lane at ‘The Sporting Side’, part of the talks hosted by Madras Musings celebrating Madras Day.

In conversation with Srinivasa Ramanujam, Deputy Editor of *The*

Hindu (Metroplus), the five-time Olympian spoke about the times when he would cycle from Choolaimedu to Mylapore to attend training sessions. “I owe a lot of my success to the city's thriving table tennis culture. I had so many champions to look up to. The club culture here - where we focus on overall growth rather than just individual sporting growth - helped me hone my skills,” he recalled.

Sharath, who studied at Padma Seshadri Bala Bhavan and Loyola College, went on to represent India at the highest level, becoming a force to reckon with in the world table tennis circuit. “I have always been a proud Chennaiite. During the time when I lived and trained in Europe, primarily Germany, I would miss the city and my mother's cooking a lot.”

Now retired from table tennis, the champion is actively looking at giving back to the sport that gave him name and fame. Part of that will be his involvement in a High Performance centre at Melkottaiyur, a training facility dedicated to grooming future champions. “My unfulfilled dream was to win an Olympic medal for India in table tennis. We hope to achieve that through the younger generation of table tennis talents.”

Seven Chennai citizens from different fields were honoured at this initiative by KSA Trust

Meet the 2026 'Champions of Chennai'

The 13th Champions of Chennai Awards were presented at a function held at Dakshinamurthy auditorium, RK Mutt Road, Mylapore.

An initiative of KSA Trust, a non-profit organisation, the 'Champion of Chennai Award' is given to seven Chennai citizens who have made a difference in the fields of Arts & Culture, Education, Enterprise, Healthcare, Science, Social Initiative, and Sports.

The chief guest for the function was Irai Anbu, former chief secretary to the Government of Tamil Nadu. The award consists of a specially designed trophy and a citation. The inspirational stories of the seven champions were released during the event, and are available at

www.championsofchennai.org.

The awardees for 2026

Humour Club International - Triplicane Chapter: A Chennai-based organisation dedicated to promoting wholesome and meaningful entertainment through clean humour.

Ravi Kasi Venkatraman: 55-year-old Headmaster of Maraimalai Adigal Government Higher Secondary School, Pallavaram has introduced a range of initiatives aimed at addressing the needs of students from diverse backgrounds.

Murray & Co. Auction House: Founded on February 10, 1927 at modest office near the Madras High Court, today the firm is one of the largest auction house in South India.

Platelet Patrons Charitable



The awardees seen with Irai Anbu, former chief secretary; and (below) winners of the quiz competition



Trust (Platelet Club): a voluntary blood donation organisation dedicated to connecting blood donors with patients in need. Founded in 2013 by Srivatsav Vema, the Trust has played a vital role in saving hundreds of lives in and around Chennai through its committed blood donation initiatives.

Besant Animal Memorial Dispensary (BMAD): A specialised outreach programme of The Theosophical Society, and one of the largest animal shelters in the heart of Chennai, BMAD rehabili-

tate and find homes for seriously unwell stray animals.

Mahanaim Boxing Club: V. Saranraj, a national-level boxer and NIS-certified coach, trains local youth, often for free, with a strong emphasis on empowering girls and fostering competitive talent, such as state-level medalists.

Garuda Aerospace Limited: A drone technology company engaged in the design, development, manufacturing, and deployment of drones and related services across multiple industry segments.

Quiz Champions

The annual quiz competition conducted by KSA Trust has grown over the years. From 26 schools last year, this year there were 55 institutions that took part. Winners are celebrated with individual gift vouchers and a plaque for the schools they represent.

The winners for 2026 are: Padma Seshadri Bala Bhavan Senior Secondary School, KK Nagar

National Public School, Gopalapuram (1st runner-up) and Maharishi Vidya Mandir, Chetput (second runner up)

Little 'national leaders'



ShikshaViharam, a play school in Mandaveli, celebrated Independence Day with a quiz competition and a craft session themed on freedom. On August 14, a fancy dress, speech and art display of children on 'Future and Green India' was showcased. Children dressed up as national leaders and spoke a few lines about themselves.

Wisdom memoir about Seetha Paati

What does it mean to live lightly – on an everyday basis? Chitra Ravi, founder and CEO of Chrysalis, found her answer not in a book, but in her grandmother's kitchen.

She Ate First – The Seetha Paati Way of Living Lightly is a wisdom memoir about Seetha Paati – a South Indian woman who raised 12 children, outlived four of them, crossed wartime India by train, and moved cities in her 60s without complaint. She

never read a self-help book. She simply lived in a way that the Bhagavad Gita describes as the highest understanding.

The book traces 10 qualities she embodied – care, rest, release, faith, wonder, courage, contentment, surrender, and empathy – and weaves them with the author's own honest reckoning with each, across decades of life as a woman, mother, and leader, says a release.

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Celebration of talent, culture and togetherness

MRC Association recently hosted the latest edition of its flagship annual community festival, Shringara 2026, at the Mayor Ramanathan Chettiar Centre in MRC Nagar, drawing enthusiastic participation from residents across generations for an evening that celebrated creativity, culture and community spirit.

Shringara has evolved into one of Chennai's most vibrant residential community festivals, providing a platform for residents to discover and showcase their talents while strengthening neighbourhood

bonds, said a press release. The event featured an engaging blend of cultural performances, music, dance, fashion presentations, interactive experiences and family entertainment, reflecting the diversity and vibrancy of the MRC community. The occasion was graced by senior advocate P. R. Raman and Vikram Kapur, retired IAS officer, as guests of honour.

Speaking on behalf of MRC Association, the organising committee said: "Shringara is more than an annual festival; it is a celebration of the people who make our community special. Every year, it offers



Residents of MRC Nagar walk the ramp at Shringara 2026.

residents a stage to express themselves, discover hidden talents and create lasting memories with family and neighbours.

The overwhelming response to this year's edition reinforces the spirit of togetherness that defines MRC Nagar."

The Association also acknowledged the tireless efforts of its volunteers, performers, sponsors and resident participants whose commitment transformed Shringara 2026 into a memorable community celebration. As the curtains came down on another successful edition, Shringara 2026 reaffirmed MRC Association's commitment to fostering meaningful community engagement through culture, creativity and shared experiences—making it a landmark event in Chennai's residential community calendar.

PLAN YOUR WEEK

Sadya at Sangeetha Veg

On August 26, Sangeetha Veg Restaurant is serving the traditional Onam sadya.

The sadya will feature crisp banana chips, 'sarkara upperi', 'pachadi', 'thoran', 'kootu curry', 'olan', 'kalan' and 'inji puli', along with pickles, 'pappadam', 'pazham', 'parippu' and 'nei', more 'kachiyathu' and other accompaniments. The feast culminates in the irresistible 'pradhaman'.

The Onam sadya at Sangeetha Veg is served at its three outlets - Adyar (9003003087), Virugambakam (7823958667), and Anna Nagar (8680001379) from 11 a.m. to 3 p.m. Dine-in bookings can be made at No. 9003003090. Customers can also book for takeaway and home delivery within a 3-kilometer radius. The Onam sadya can also be ordered online through Swiggy and Zomato, said a release.

Payasam mela and Onam sadya

Rain Drops, the hospitality venture from Kerala Tourism Development Hotels and Resorts at Greams Road, is celebrating the Onam with a payasam mela and traditional Onam sadya till August 26.

The payasam mela features a delightful variety of traditional Kerala payasams. The highlights include pineapple payasam, chakka payasam, pazham payasam, palada payasam, parippu pradhaman, ada pradhaman, kadala parippu payasam, carrot payasam, paal payasam and gothambu payasam.

A traditional Onam sadya will be

served on August 23rd and August 26th with 29 items. A special buffet Onam sadya will also be available, featuring an array of authentic Kerala delicacies.

Cost of payasam is ₹450 per litre and ₹280 for half litre; Onam sadya is ₹899 per person and buffet sadya is ₹599 per person.

The Onam celebrations were inaugurated on August 21 by Rajya Sabha member Praveen Chakravarty.

For bookings and enquiries, WhatsApp: 9498410098, 9188127752 | Phone: 044-28292150

Silk expo in Triplicane

The National Silk Expo happening at Kalivanar Arangam in Triplicane features a wide collection of cotton and silk saris and dress materials.

Jute silks in vibrant colours, polished

and raw tussars, kantha-worked saris, dhakai jamdani, linen sari from West Bengal, double weave ikkats, ghicha silks and cottons are some of the other attractions.

The exhibition will conclude on August 25. For details, call 9412258826

Chandragiri Fort and Madras

As part of Madras Week celebration, Storycorner at Bookmine is having a presentation on 'The Chandragiri Fort and its connection to the founding of Madras' on August 30; 9.30 a.m. at Hotel Palmgrove, Kodambakkam High Road

Sudha Umashanker, author, columnist and storyteller will be the speaker.

To register, Whatsapp 98402 47624

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Coffee House opens third outlet in Chennai



Cafe Coffee House has opened its third outlet, located on Dr Thirumoorthy Nagar Main Road,

near GG Hospital, Nungambakam.

The evening launch was marked by music and special

offers, bringing together family, friends, and influencers.

The menu at the outlet includes burgers, pizzas, sandwiches, wraps, pasta, fried chicken, seafood, grilled dishes, and snacks, as well as coffee and other beverages.

Kishore, the outlet founder, says the idea of opening a cafe outlet stemmed from an experience when he was studying in college.

"During my college days, menus at cafes were expensive and would cost around ₹350. My pocket money at the time was around ₹100-₹150. The outlet will offer a café-style experience at more approachable prices."

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